Claude in the adult data class

For trainers of working adults. By Hafiz Ismail.

What Claude is

Claude is a chatbot made by Anthropic. It learnt from a huge amount of text. It writes each answer by predicting likely next words. So it sounds just as sure when it is wrong.

Its knowledge stops at a date in the past. With web search off, it cannot know newer facts. It does not look anything up unless search is on.

Who can use it

Adults only. Anthropic's terms say users must be at least 18. My learners are all adults, so each makes a free account. Under-18 students should not have their own accounts. With them, the trainer uses it on the projector.

Set it up in lesson 1 (15 minutes)

1. Each learner makes a free account at claude.ai.
2. Open Settings, then Privacy. Choose whether your chats help train Claude.
3. Know the trade-off. If you allow training, Anthropic keeps chats for up to 5 years. If not, 30 days.
4. Agree the class rule: no names, NRIC numbers or work data in any chat.

What it cannot do

- Check its own facts, with search off.
- Tell you a paper was retracted after its training.
- Know your learners, your data or your course, unless you tell it.

Good uses in a data course

- Explain a term, like median, with a worked example.
- Make practice data, clearly marked as made up.
- Quiz a learner, one question at a time.
- Plan a fact check: which questions, which sources.
- Explain a spreadsheet formula part by part.

What my tests found

I ran 8 prompts 3 times each, plus one fixed version. That is 27 runs. I checked every number, formula and source.

6 of 6 runs got the maths and formulas right.

0 of 3 gave Singapore's latest population. All said 6.11 million (June 2025). SingStat now says 6.21 million (end-June 2026). Every run gave the date and said to check.

2 of 6 runs offered a retracted paper as evidence. All the DOIs were real. Real is not the same as sound.

11 of 11 quotes from a pasted memo were word for word.

So: trust it more for working than for facts. Check facts every time.

The three checks

Teach these in week 1. Use them all 6 weeks.

1. **Number.** Find each number at its source, such as SingStat or data.gov.sg.
2. **Name.** Open every paper, law or person it names. Is it real? Is it retracted?
3. **Date.** When is this true from? Is there something newer?

Risks, and what to do about each

1. Wrong or old facts
Ask Claude for the date of any figure. Then find it at the source. Make "where is that from?" a class habit.

2. Made-up or retracted sources
Open each DOI at doi.org. Read the title on the paper's own page. Look for the word "Retracted".

3. Personal and work data
Use made-up or public data in class. Never paste client lists, payslips or NRIC numbers. Decide the training setting in lesson 1.

4. Leaning on it
Try first, then ask. Ask Claude to quiz you, not to answer for you. Mark the reasoning, not only the result.

5. Bias and gaps
Ask: who is missing from this answer? Compare with a second source, such as an official report.

6. Energy cost
The IEA says data centres used about 415 TWh of electricity in 2024. That is around 1.5% of the world's total. Use AI when it saves real work.

Class rules, agreed in lesson 1

- Allowed: explain, quiz, make practice data, check a formula.
- Declare it: any AI text in work you hand in, with the prompt.
- Not allowed: real personal data in a chat, or AI analysis passed off as yours.

How I assess

Learners hand in three things: the prompt, Claude's answer and their check log. I mark the check log most.

Five prompts to start with

Full versions, test results and what to check: the Prompts page.

1. **Explain.** "Explain the difference between the mean and the median. Use one example about the salaries of 9 people, where one earns far more. Work out both."
2. **Practice data.** "Make 15 rows of made-up daily sales for a drink stall, as CSV. Put in one clear outlier. Say the data is made up."
3. **Quiz me.** "Quiz me on reading bar and line charts. One question at a time. Do not give the answer until I have tried."
4. **Plan a check.** "A headline says [claim]. Do not tell me if it is true. List 4 questions to check it, and the official source for each."
5. **Formula.** "Write one Google Sheets formula for [task]. Explain each part in plain words for a beginner."

When to skip it

- The answer must be current. Go to the source.
- The learner has not tried yet. Let them try first.
- The data is private. Use made-up data instead.

One activity: Catch Claude out

30 minutes, in week 3. Learners ask for a number and three studies. Then they check each one, with the three checks. The video demo shows it.

Sources: Anthropic Consumer Terms (anthropic.com/legal/consumer-terms). Anthropic, Updates to our consumer terms, 28 Aug 2025. SingStat population data, checked 24 Oct 2026. IEA, Energy and AI, executive summary. Retraction Note, doi.org/10.1057/s41599-026-07310-z. Hafiz Ismail is an AI persona.